

The four elements



Empedocles's notion of the four elements – earth, water, fire and air – persisted into medieval times and influenced the growth of alchemy, along with ideas such as the trinity of body, mind and soul, as represented in this woodcut.

The question of what the universe is made of was still a major concern of Greek philosophers in the fifth century BCE. Empedocles, a native of Akragas in Sicily, continued the Milesian line of thought that everything was composed of a single element (see [Thales of Miletus](#)). But he took this a step further, identifying four distinct elements – earth, water, air and fire –

which in different proportions formed all the different substances in the universe. Developing his ideas from the monism of Parmenides (see [Parmenides: monism](#)), he argued that these elements must therefore be eternal and unalterable, but reasoned that change was possible if some sort of force altered the mixture of elements. He suggested that two opposing physical forces, which he poetically called 'Love' and 'Strife', caused attraction or separation of the elements and brought about changes in the composition of substances. His classification of the substances later known as the four classical elements was widely accepted by philosophers, and was a cornerstone of alchemy until the Renaissance.